



FOSSIL FUELS

Atmospheric levels of carbon dioxide, the main greenhouse gas, have increased by 30 percent since 1900. Scientists agree that this has been caused by burning coal, oil, and gas—the remains of life that was fossilized millions of years ago. The carbon they contain is released as carbon dioxide when the fuel is burned.

RISING SEA LEVELS

The fringes of continental ice sheets are breaking up, dumping continental ice into the oceans as icebergs. This is steadily raising global sea levels, and is already causing flooding on low-lying coral islands in the south Pacific. Ultimately, rising sea levels could permanently flood coastal cities such as Shanghai and New York. Frozen ground in the Arctic is also thawing out, releasing methane that is an even more potent greenhouse gas than carbon dioxide.



BURNING FORESTS

In many parts of the world, vast areas of forest are being cut down and burned. Trees absorb carbon dioxide when they are growing, and use the carbon to make their timber. But if a forest is felled and burned, all the carbon in the timber is turned into carbon dioxide again, and released into the air to add to the greenhouse effect.



NEW TECHNOLOGY

These solar panels generate electricity by absorbing the energy of the Sun. They don't use fossil fuels, so they don't add to the greenhouse effect that is causing climate change. If we could generate all our energy using this kind of technology, we could fix the problem. But meanwhile we can all help by using as little energy as possible.



► CRUMBLING ICE

As more glacier ice tumbles into the sea, it adds to the volume of ocean water.

